grade explosives en-route to the dam.[139] Allegedly, the Quetta *shura* had given orders to blow the dam, and the explosives had come from Iran.[140]

The then serving governor of Herat, Saba confirmed that Iran was bent on destroying the dam.[141] Not just the Salma Dam, Iran was also opposed to the Badkhshabad hydroelectric facility in the Farah province, which Indian engineers surveyed in 2008.[142] When asked why, he wryly (though unconvincingly) replied, 'you should ask the Iranians why they do this'.[143] To underplay differences Mukhopadhaya ruled out that India was siding with Kabul in its dispute with Iran.[144] However, according to senior FICCI official deeply involved in coordinating India's trade and development activities in Afghanistan, New Delhi's differences with Iran on the Salma Dam 'is a very controversial political topic' that no one talks much about.[145] Menon agrees that the Salma dam was a project with which Iran had a problem, but these differences were sorted out at a working level and never allowed to blow out of proportion. Despite Afghan accusations of the IRGC funding the anti-government elements to destroy the dam, Menon, just like Khare, was skeptical about it. There were a host of loose militants and criminals in that part of Afghanistan making it difficult to point a finger on any one entity regarding the discovery of explosives. In fact, according to Menon, *Jundullah*, a Sunni militant organisation based out of Balochistan in Pakistan but operating on both sides of the Pakistan-Iran border might have been behind the act. It was a hint that instead of Iran doing such activities against Indian projects, it is possible that the origin of the plot lay in Pakistan, and the intent of the plan was to drive a wedge between India and Iran by bombing the dam. Tehran had no problems with other Indian projects in Afghanistan and was supportive of India's engagement in the country by and large.[146] Though India-Iran relations within Afghanistan are much deeper and complex than a hydro-project (and the Salma dam is not a big enough issue to spark bilateral discord), it does indicate that India and Iran's vision of an Afghanistan that is stable, sovereign, and capable, may not always match.[147]

The impact of these differences was visible. By 2006, Indian diplomats had started worrying that a breakdown in bilateral relations with Iran (over the nuclear issue) may jeopardise India's access to Afghanistan and Central Asia.[148] Tehran already used India's dependence for connectivity to Afghanistan and